

Tantra of the Ornament of the Glorious Charnel Ground

Śrī Śmaśāna Alaṃkāra Tantra · Toh 402 · Derge Kangyur

དཔལ་དུ་ཁདྲོ་ཀའི་རྩ་གའི་རྩ།

Toh 402 in the Kangyur is a tantric text known in English as the Glorious Ornament of the Charnel Ground, corresponding to the Sanskrit title Śrī Śmaśāna Alaṃkāra Tantra and preserved in Tibetan as ཀའི་རྩ་གའི་རྩ་ཀའི་རྩ་གའི་རྩ་ or similar. It belongs to the class of Buddhist tantras and concerns the symbolic and ritual significance of the charnel ground, describing its general and specific features, its directional divisions, and its ornaments within the context of a tantric dialogue between the Blessed One and a vajra-hearted interlocutor. The text is framed as a question-and-answer exchange exploring the nature of the charnel ground as a sacred and terrifying abode associated with great bliss and wrathful practice, situating it within the cosmology of the measureless palace and vajra fence. It was translated into Tibetan by the Indian master Gayābhara together with the monk-translator Śākya Yeshé, and it appears in the Kangyur immediately following the completion of the related Glorious Secret Nectar Tantra, suggesting a close association between these two works in the tantric corpus.

They were pleased. The King of Tantras, the Glorious Secret Nectar, is complete. It was translated by the Indian master Gayābhara and the translator, the monk Śākya Yeshé.

Homage to the glorious Great Bliss. Homage to the Great Terrifier. Having bowed the crown of my head to his feet, I ask: what is the charnel ground? What are its ornaments? What is the tantra? Who is the King?

The Blessed One declared: Excellent, Vajra-heart, excellent! Listen well and hold it well. First the charnel ground shall be explained, both in general and in its specific features. Outside the measureless palace, within the vajra fence, is the general abode of great terror. The specific ones are in the east and the other directions. To avert attachment to the vessel-world, up to and including the black iron mountains, the vajra fence itself is that very limit. The great one is twenty cubits; the small one extends as far as a single cubit. Any maṇḍala other than these has surely exceeded the measure.

The eight aggregates of consciousness, the eight conceptual thoughts — as signs of their subjugation, eight charnel grounds are arranged in the directions

and in the direction-free space. As signs of possessing the eight qualities of the eight assemblies, eight trees are arranged in order. Likewise as signs of subduing the eight venomous ones, eight nāgas (serpent spirits) are arranged in order. As signs that the eight assemblies have overcome the ten non-virtues, the direction-guardians are arranged in order. Because benefit is rendered to sentient beings through body and speech, rain-clouds are placed there. This very great and terrifying charnel ground is the cause of the non-duality of skillful means and wisdom. It is taught as eightfold in overcoming conceptual thought. Because it is beautiful, it is an ornament.

In order to make this clear, the charnel ground shall be explained first. In the east, a great fierce and dark one; in the south, a great yellow one for Hāhā; in the west, an unbearable red one; in the north, a great lush and green Tshangtching. The one with fire and whirling has it thus: at the corners free from truth it holds the blazing. At the wind-corner, places such as the hells abide — in the one possessed of power, it has a defined form.

Bhūce, Rikhī, and Tsaśānī are placed on the surface of the earth, to the outer east. Patali and Bāsanī are placed underground, to the outer west. The characteristics of these charnel grounds include: blazing, burning, and not burning; heaps of bones and skulls and the like; risen corpses and assemblies of spirits; and terrifying forms accompanied by the cries of jackals.

In the east, the Śirīṣa tree; in the south, the Aśvattha tree; in the west, the Vaṅgeliṅ tree; in the north, it is definitely the Cūta tree. Like those above: the Nyagrodha, the Parkatī, the Lcugpāthā — these are placed at the fire-corner and the powerful corner. This is held to be their form as renowned.

In the east, Śakra (Indra) abides; in the south, Yama abides; in the west, the lord of nāgas abides; in the north, yakṣas truly abide. At the southeast corner, fire abides; at the southwest corner, a demon abides; at the northwest corner, wind is placed; at the northeast corner, the Powerful One is placed. Sun and moon in the east, the earth-lord in the west — place them according to their renowned form.

In the east, Wealth-Expanding abides; in the south is the Restrainer; in the west, Power-Source; Padma is in the north; Great Lotus at the fire-corner; Hulu Hulu is placed at the demon-corner; the Lineage-Holder at the wind-corner; the Conch-Keeper at the powerful corner. The malicious one is placed in the form of an emanation. Distinguish them by the distinctions of color and lineage.

In the east, place a white rain-cloud; in the south, place Pūmitī; in the west, terror abides completely; in the north, Abaya truly abides. The blue-fish one truly abides at the Ghanī demon-corner. At the wind-corner, Parśāna. These eight fierce ones, eight rain-clouds: the color of madder, the color of saffron, the color of the sky, the color of smoke —

Cloud-colored, cloud-formed —

four and four in each direction from the east.

These inner signs manifest outwardly.

First, the excellence of abandonment is perfected;

then, the excellence of primordial wisdom is perfected;

the excellence of self-knowing awareness is perfected;

and the excellence of benefit to others is perfected.

These fearsome ones abide as signs.

Then the inner charnel grounds and so forth:

the skin is the vajra enclosure;

the bones are definitively the vajra canopy;

the shoulders and the adjacent shoulders,

the thighs and likewise the adjacent thighs —

these eight are definitively the eight charnel grounds.

The four joints of the knees and the four adjacent knee-joints,

the four joints of the arms and the four adjacent arm-joints —

these eight are the eight inner trees.

The joints and likewise the adjacent joints,

above and below, four and four —

these are held to be the inner directional guardians.

The soles of the feet and their adjacent parts,

above and below, are likewise the eight nāgas.

The tips and likewise their adjacent tips —

these eight are the eight rain-clouds:

the sign that conceptuality (vikalpa) holds no sway in the generation stage.

The eight charnel grounds abide within:

through thorough knowing of the nature of channels and winds,

the eight inner trees abide.

In order to tame gross malevolent forces,

the eight nāgas truly abide within.

Because one acts for oneself and likewise acts for others,

the eight rain-clouds abide within.

Then there is also the secret charnel ground:

at the tip of the nose — eight channels, eight charnel grounds;

at the navel — eight channels, eight trees;

at the heart — eight channels, eight directional guardians;

at the throat — eight channels, eight nāgas;

at the crown of the head — eight channels, eight rain-clouds.

These are the signs that conceptuality holds no sway in the secret.

The eight charnel grounds abide in the secret.

Because everything appears as bliss,

the eight trees truly abide in the secret.

In order to slay the malevolence of subtle conceptual marks,

the eight nāgas are set in place.

Because through bliss one acts for oneself and through union acts for others,

the rain-clouds are therefore set in place.

Then there is also the fourth charnel ground:

the eight consciousnesses are definitively those very eight charnel grounds.

The charnel grounds and so forth — the eight — are those very trees;

the remaining three and the five clusters of feeling

are definitively the eight directional guardians.

The six afflictions and their two derivatives —

these eight are the eight nāgas.

Five and four and three —

these are the eight rain-clouds of the fourth.

These are the signs that subject-object duality (gzung-'dzin) and conceptuality hold no sway;

these are definitively the eight charnel grounds of the fourth.

The extensive qualities of knowing, beginning with the ten powers,
are definitively signified by the eight trees.

As a sign of taming malevolent conceptuality,

the eight nāgas are definitively set.

As a sign of accomplishing the welfare of sentient beings

through the two form-bodies (nirmāṇakāya and saṃbhogakāya),

the eight rain-clouds are set.

The directional guardians are known from the guru's own mouth,
and all their individual distinctions
are also to be known from the guru's own mouth.
The term "continuum" — what is called the outer, inner, and secret continuum
—
this, O King, is supremely distinguished.

Moreover, the words I have spoken,
though spoken as a single utterance,
appear separately as many.

Through the distinctions of the many modes of Dharma,
through the distinctions of the many kinds of aspiration,
through the distinctions of the many kinds of perception,
the vehicles are without limit at their edge.

The mental supports and branches are inconceivable.

A guru who follows in my wake,
having thoroughly traversed the grounds,
possessed of the ten aspects of suchness and endowed with higher knowledge
—

let such a one speak up to sixteen utterances.

The five fields of knowledge are to be practiced by the learned.

Through the prophecy of the ḍākinīs,
what was begun is made definitive by the four edges.

Without receiving such pith instructions as these,
whoever practices the view and conduct of mantra —
they ruin themselves and ruin others.

In this very life, hell and such places torment them.

Therefore, those who desire spiritual attainment
should please the holy guru
and receive the holy pith instructions.

Without having found the certain view and conduct,
those who engage with secret deities and conduct,
who act according to aspiration alone,
who override afflictions and so forth,
and who practice as though it were secret mantra —
these are corrupt thieves, unworthy ones;
in this very life they are born in hell.

As for birth in a first existence:
the bright fortnight, the dark fortnight, and the junctions — three.

At the beginning and end of the Sinhalese reckoning,
and at the time when conception occurs through craving for the fruit —
if one performs the practice at all those times,
and if one enters into the inner wind of the elements,
one accumulates the bases of illness and generates the bases of illness;
there arise loss of vitality and violation of celibacy.

Against these, the weapons of desire are:
distraction, fire, and cauterization —
and thereafter, by the lord of the clan from without.

As for the times of birth into existence:
avoid the intervals of three days, five days,
seven days, and nine days.

Thus, the meaning of the supreme king of tantras
is entrusted to you — hold it well.

Then all the assembled retinue became joyful and delighted, and they
rejoiced. The glorious —

Translator's Notes

- Several proper names in this passage are Sanskrit transliterations preserved in Tibetan phonetic rendering: Bhūce, Rikhī, Tsaśānī, Patali, Bāsanī, Śirīṣa, Aśvattha, Vaṅgeliṅ, Cūta, Nyagrodha, Parkatī, Pūmitī, Abaya, Ghanī, and Parśāna. These appear to be the names of specific charnel grounds, trees, and directional guardians associated with the eight great charnel grounds of tantric cosmography. Some of these phonetic reconstructions are uncertain, particularly Vaṅgeliṅ, which may represent Vaṅguliṅ or a similar Sanskrit tree name, and Lcugpāthā, whose Sanskrit original is unclear. The passage ends mid-sentence, suggesting this is an excerpt from a longer tantra. The title rendered from Sanskrit is Śrī Śmaśāna Alaṃkāra Tantra Rāja, the Glorious King of Tantras Adorned with Charnel Grounds.

- The passage is a highly technical tantric text enumerating correspondences between external maṇḍala elements (charnel grounds, trees, directional guardians, nāgas, rain-clouds) and internal subtle-body locations (channels, navel, heart, throat, crown) and then psycho-cognitive factors (the eight consciousnesses, six afflictions, etc.). The "fourth charnel ground" refers to a fourth category of charnel ground in the secret or innermost level of the schema, distinct from the outer, inner, and secret levels treated earlier.

The final line — "the bright fortnight, the dark fortnight, and the junctions — three" — appears to be the opening of a new section on auspicious times for practice or birth, and is left as rendered; the passage ends abruptly mid-topic.

The phrase rendered "the remaining three and the five clusters of feeling" for "lhag ma gsum dang tshor tshogs Inga" identifies three unnamed factors plus the five feeling-aggregates or groups; the precise referent of "the remaining three" is not fully clear from context alone and

would require the surrounding commentary tradition to specify.

- The opening phrase "Sinhalese reckoning" renders සිංහල, which likely refers to a Sinhalese or Sri Lankan calendrical system for reckoning the fortnight divisions mentioned in the preceding passage. This is a technical astrological or medical context within the tantra, and the precise referent of "beginning and end" in this system is not entirely clear from the passage alone. The phrase "weapons of desire" is an unusual compound; it may refer to antidotal practices or ritual counter-measures against the afflictions named, and the exact technical sense of සැරවිද්‍යා, ධර්ම, and සැරවිද්‍යා as a triad warrants attention in a full commentary. The text breaks off mid-sentence at සැර, which is the beginning of a title or colophon.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.